Same Seat, Different Lengths

Moderated by Laurie Williams, this main-stage conversation brought together five CEOs at different stages of their leadership journeys: Manpreet Singh, Sanjay Gavani, Eran Gill, Glenn Weinstein, and Chris Barbin. Together, they reflected on the judgment behind decisions about talent, investors, growth, capital, and AI.

The conversation was less about finding one leadership playbook than about learning from different perspectives: building a company's approach in real time, drawing on hard-won experience, and knowing when to act—or wait.

Session notes

People and leadership

- **Sanjay Gavani** reflected on hiring for what a business will need as it grows, rather than assuming someone's past success will translate to a new role.
- **Eran Gill** emphasised trusting and empowering the people a CEO hires, rather than limiting them through micromanagement.
- **Glenn Weinstein** reflected on staying too long with investors who did not believe in CloudSmith, and the importance of surrounding a company with people who want it to succeed.

Growth and capital

- **Chris Barbin** recalled how Appirio's founders retained unanimous approval for every hire despite advice that the process would not scale. He also discussed the difficulty of growing through services-company acquisitions, especially when integrating cultures.
- **Manpreet Singh** described the decisions he is working through around capital for BOT: whether and when to raise, whom to raise from, and how to deploy it. He shared his father's advice that a leader does not always need to make a move.

Leading in the AI era

- **Glenn** described employees using AI to build internal analytics, dashboards, and workflows that might previously have remained in an IT backlog.

- **Eran** discussed a measured approach to AI adoption in services, where teams work within customers' environments and need to consider the impact of their tools and processes.
- **Sanjay** contrasted introducing AI in an established organisation with building an AI-native company, where it can be part of the operating model from the outset.
- **Manpreet** described AI as an accelerant for GCCs, discussing partner innovation and reskilling alongside ways to automate and reduce the cost of building GCCs.